

The Pastoral Spiral

An Approach to
Social Justice Action

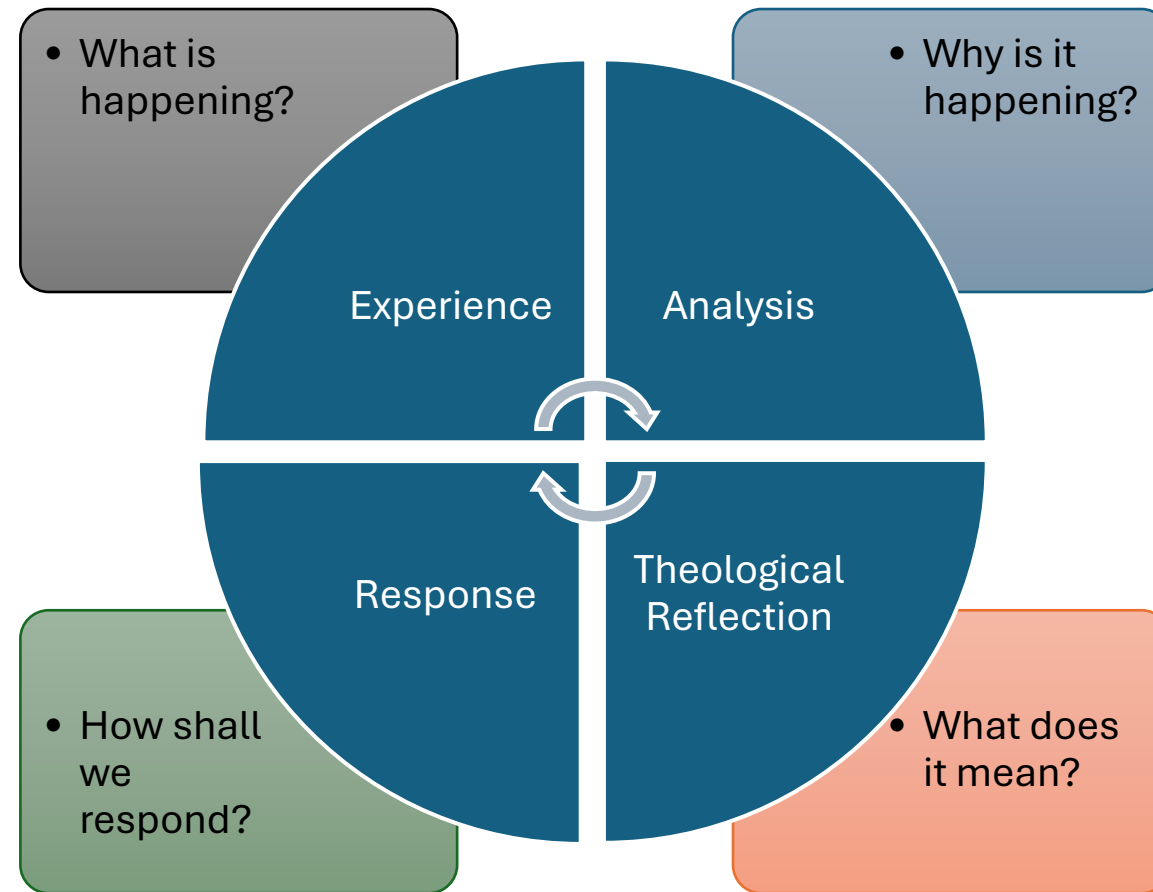
What is the Pastoral Spiral?

- A flexible framework that can be used for pastoral, academic or community action purposes.
- Known as the pastoral circle, pastoral cycle or pastoral spiral.
- The 4 moments are known as:
 - Experience, or contact;
 - Social analysis, or simply analysis;
 - Theological reflection, or reflection;
 - Pastoral planning, or response.
- Not a closed circle: action leads to a new reality, new experience to the examined.

Origins & Influences

- A pastoral theology method developed by Joe Holland & Peter Henriot SJ
 - First described in the booklet *Social Analysis* published by the Centre of Concern in 1980.
 - A revised and expanded edition *Social Analysis: Linking Faith & Justice* was published by Orbis in 1983.
- Influences include:
 - Cardinal Joseph Cardijn - 'see, judge, act' method
 - Juan Luis Segundo - the 'hermeneutic circle'
 - the methodology of modern Catholic Social Teaching
 - the spirituality of St Ignatius of Loyola.

4 Moments, 4 Questions



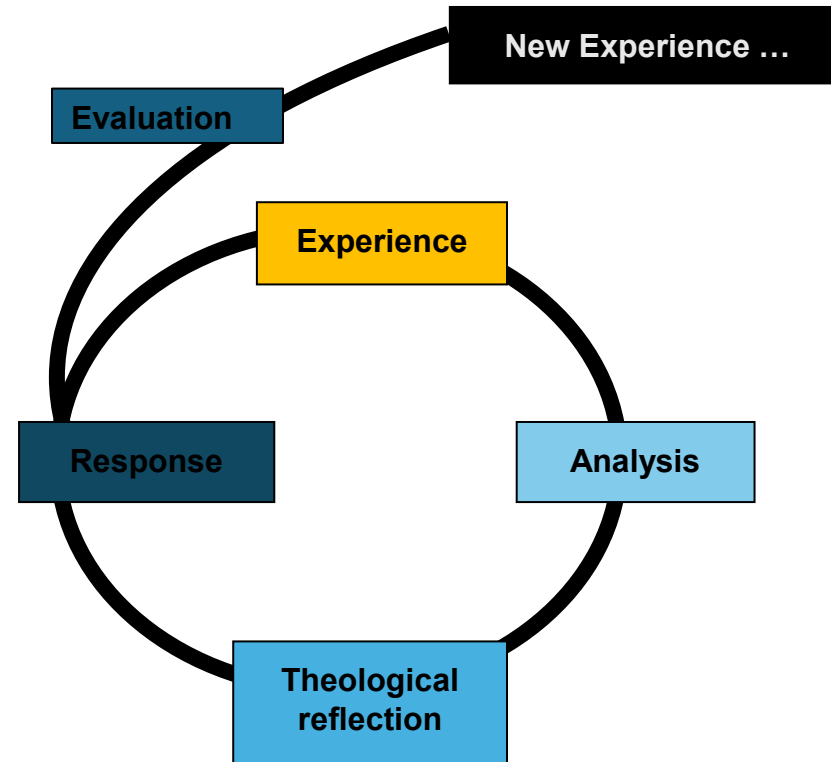
Hearts, Heads & Hands

- **Affective dimension:** Immersion or contact in the experience moment help us get in touch with feelings – paying attention to our hearts
- **Cognitive dimension:** Experience and analysis help us to achieve better understanding – using our heads
- **Volitional dimension:** Theological reflection helps us to get in touch with deeper values – aligning our heads and our hearts with the will of God
- **Effective dimension:** Planning for improved responses to issues and situations – using our hands

Experience: Contemplatives in Action

We start from the contemplation of our world, from the data of human experience.

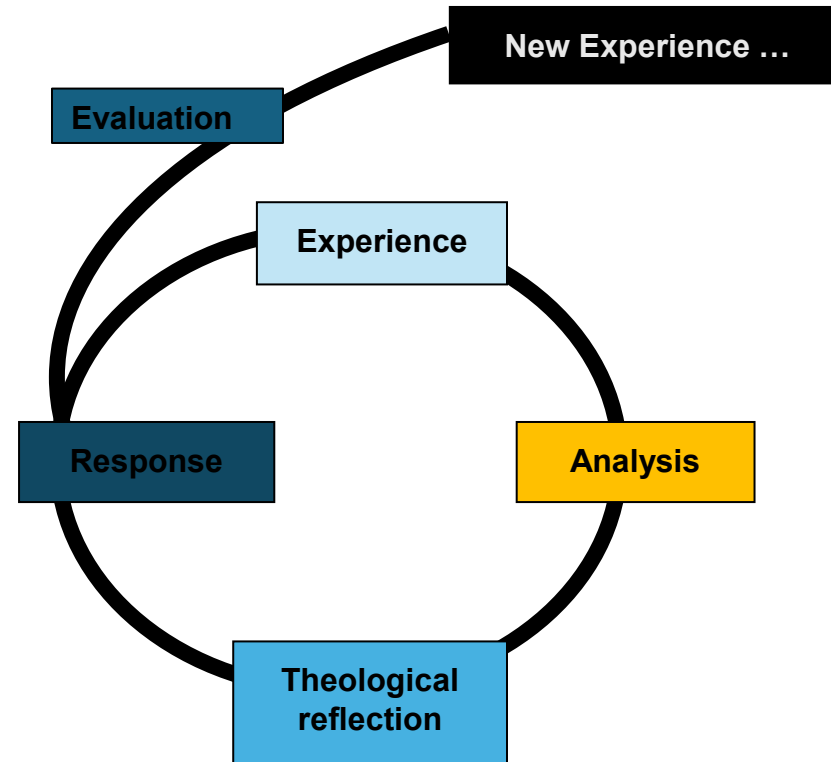
- Describe the problem:
 - What is the lived experience?
 - What is happening to people?
- Are we listening to the people most directly affected?
- Can we / do we share their experience? Do we need to undertake exposure or immersion?



Analysis: Called to Learned Ministry

We take reality very seriously - this is where God continues to act and to communicate with us. We investigate reality in a systematic and analytical way:

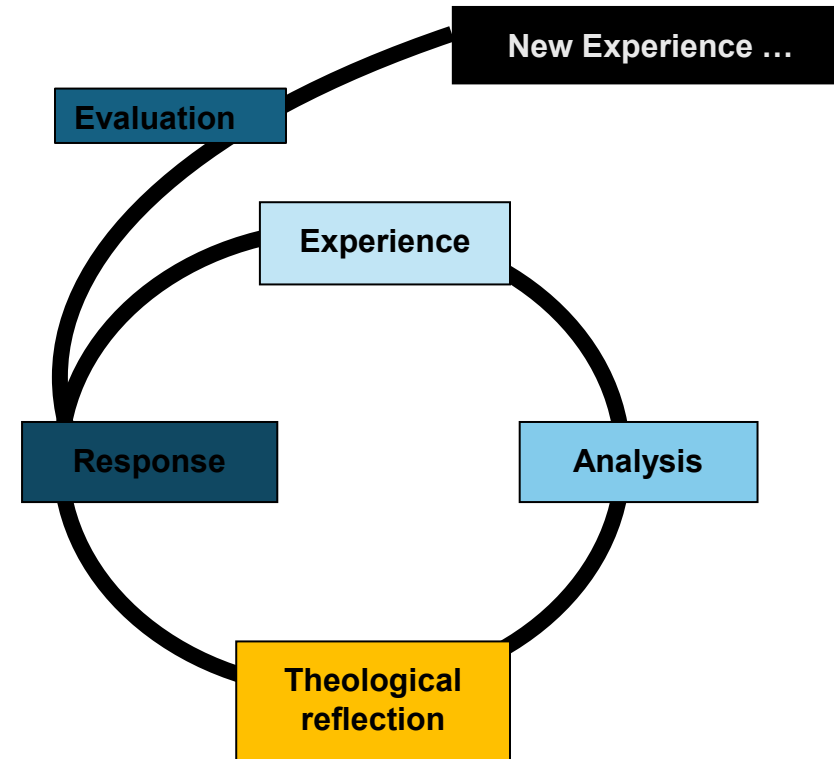
- What are the **causes** of the issue or situation? (These may be historical, political, economic, social or cultural)
- What are the **consequences**?
- How are these elements linked?
- Who are the **key actors**? (subjects, duty bearers, agents of influence, decision makers)



Theological Reflection: Finding God in All Things

We reflect on the situation or issue in the light of the Gospel, Church teaching and our prayer:

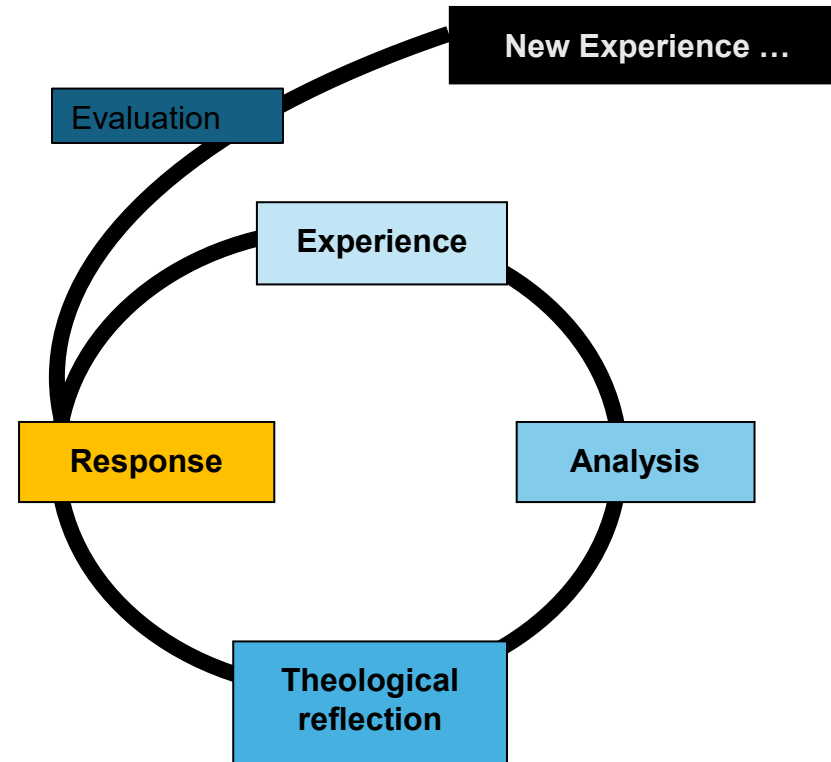
- Are Gospel values being upheld or denied?
- How do the Scriptures speak to this issue or situation?
- How do the principles of CST speak to this issue or situation?
- What does Church teaching have to say about it?
- Can the experience of the Christian community through time help us to discern this situation or issue?
- Where is God in all this?



Response: Discerning God's Call

We also draw on reason, human knowledge and tradition to discern our love response to God's calls to us:

- What should individuals, parishes, groups & agencies, the diocese/broader Church do?
- Does our action include:
 - Service of the poor or marginalized
 - Education or awareness raising
 - Advocacy & transformation of causes
 - Faith formation?



Going Round Again: Seeking the *Magis*

- We can start with whatever information is available to us - making modest responses based on what we already know & understand can help us to avoid 'analysis paralysis'.
- Our responses will never be perfect or complete - they can continue to deepen as we gain more knowledge & experience.
- We need to evaluate our action & critically examine our methods - has our action led to some change in the situation, ourselves, or our understanding of the situation? What is happening *now*?
- We continually seek the *magis* - to go deeper and be of ever greater service.

For Reflection & Discussion

- Does our way of working for social justice touch on each moment in the Pastoral Spiral?
- At their 34th General Congregation, the Society of Jesus decided that:
 - “...every Jesuit ministry can and should promote justice in at least one or more of the following ways:
 - (a) direct service and accompaniment of the poor;
 - (b) developing awareness of the demands of justice joined to the responsibility to achieve it;
 - (c) participating in social mobilization for the creation of a more just social order”. (Decree 3, n 19)
- Does our action correspond to one or more of these categories?